

The Boston Globe

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MONDAY, MAY 12, 2025

HBCU scholars plan for an uncertain future

In federal rollback of DEI, professors lose grants, students fear end of tuition aid

By Asia Alexander
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Ashley Preston was thrilled when she received a \$60,000 grant from the National Endowment for the Humanities in January. The associate professor of history at Howard University had planned to use the funding — reserved specifically for faculty at Historically Black Colleges and Universities — to take a sabbatical and finish her book on civil rights icon Mary McLeod Bet-

hune and the Democratic Party. Three months later, the opportunity vanished. On April 3, Preston received a termination letter. The explanation, which included phrases like “ending radical DEI programs” and “reducing federal bureaucracy,” made it clear that her grant had become collateral damage in a much larger political shift. “Everything got caught up in all of this political drama,” she said.

\$16.3 million

National Institutes of Health grant awarded to Florida A&M University's pharmacy school and its Research Centers in Minority Institutions program was abruptly canceled on March 21.

‘Everything got caught up in all of this political drama. It’s extremely disappointing.’
— Ashley Preston, of Howard University

“It’s extremely disappointing. I’ve been so busy this semester and just trying to regroup since learning about this. I haven’t figured out, you know, what I will be able to do to get that time back.” Preston is one of many HBCU scholars and students now grappling with the fallout from President Trump’s rollback of diversity, equity, and inclusion efforts across federal agencies. As his administration targets programs it deems “radical,” institutions that have long depended on federal support — particularly historically Black

COLLEGES, Page A7

Trump poised to accept lavish jet

Possible gift from Qatari royal family raises queries about conflicts of interest

By Maggie Haberman, Eric Schmitt, and Glenn Thrush
NEW YORK TIMES

The Trump administration plans to accept a luxury Boeing 747-8 plane as a donation from the Qatari royal family that will be upgraded to serve as Air Force One, which would make it one of the biggest foreign gifts ever received by the US government, four people with knowledge of the matter said. The plane would then be donated to President Trump’s presidential library when he leaves office, two senior officials said.

Democratic lawmakers and good government groups expressed outrage over the substantial ethical issues the plan raises. They cited the intersection of Trump’s official duties with his business interests in the Middle East, the immense value of the lavishly appointed plane, and the assumption that Trump would have use of it after leaving office. Sold new, a commercial Boeing 747-8 costs in the range of \$400 million.

Trump’s own private plane, known as “Trump Force One,” is an older 757 jet that first flew in the early 1990s and was then used by Microsoft co-founder Paul Allen. Trump bought it in 2011. The Qatari jet, if Trump continued flying it after leaving office, would give him a substantially newer

JET, Page A6

RALLYING FOR RAW MILK

Advocates see hopeful signs; health officials caution not to whitewash dangers



PHOTOS BY DAVID L RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

The Lolans Farm stand in Middleborough is one of a few places with a license to sell raw milk in Massachusetts.



‘The difference between cost of production and your potential income just shrunk and shrunk over the years.’

SAM SHIELDS, a third-generation dairy farmer in Middleborough, with his wife, Sue

By Nathan Metcalf
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Once a week, Matt Rumley, 40, finds time between his two jobs to make the 50-mile round trip from his home in West Roxbury to a farm in Middleborough to buy seven half-gallon jugs of raw milk for his family, including his three young sons.

A part-time CrossFit trainer, Rumley considers raw milk an essential part of his rigorous health and fitness routine.

“There’s a lot of things I noticed when I started being my own test subject,” Rumley said of his decision to start drinking raw milk during the pandemic. “The way that my skin looks, the way that my eyes look, the way that my face has changed. Belly fat melted away. My stamina in the gym doubled.”

Rumley just wishes he didn’t have to go so far out of his way for what to him should be a routine milk run. “I would much prefer to go to my local grocery store and pick up my raw milk,” he said.

That’s not possible right now in Massachusetts — or in most of the United States. But Robert F. Kennedy Jr., who in February became the nation’s top health official, has pledged to roll back regulations on raw milk and reportedly tapped Mark McAfee, chief executive of the nation’s largest raw milk producer, to advise the Food and Drug Administration “on raw milk policy and standards

MILK, Page A10

For T, anticrash system farther down the track

Agency forced to focus first on reining in speeding trains

By Shannon Larson
GLOBE STAFF

Maggie Norcross-Devin was among the passengers left bruised and shaken when the Green Line train they were riding in October abruptly sped up and derailed near Lechmere Station.

Not long after, she received a letter from the MBTA that included a handwritten note from general manager Phil Eng expressing gratitude for patronizing public transport and several promotional stickers that she found off-putting: One had a lighthearted take with a Green Line car drawn with googly-eyes.

“It was either like a big [expletive] you ... or, it was just an oversight,” said Norcross-Devin, 48, of Somerville, said of the sticker. “Either way, it was not great.”

A few months later in February, another speeding Green Line train smashed into a stationary trolley at the East Somerville Station, causing \$6.6 million in damages and injuring several on board.

In both crashes, the trains were traveling at

GREEN LINE, Page A10

A quiet path to the pinnacle of the Vatican

At the conclave, a consensus swiftly coalesced around a missionary power broker

By Jason Horowitz, Emma Bubola, and Elizabeth Dias
NEW YORK TIMES

VATICAN CITY — The cardinals electing a new pope to lead the Catholic Church left the Sistine Chapel exhausted and hungry.

A meditation to start the conclave had dragged on and pushed their first vote deep into Wednesday evening. It had resulted in an inconclusive tally, with three main contenders. Keeping their vow of secrecy, they returned to Casa Santa Marta, the guesthouse where they were sequestered without their phones, and started talking.

Over dinner, as one gluten-free cardinal picked over vegetables and others shrugged at the simple fare, they weighed their choices. Cardinal Pietro Parolin, 70, the Italian who ran the Vatican under Pope Francis, had entered the conclave as a front-



FRANCO ORIGLIA/GETTY IMAGES

runner but hadn’t received overwhelming support during the vote. The Italians were divided, and some of the cardinals in the room had become

POPE, Page A5

Pope Leo XIV held his first Mass Sunday in St. Peter’s Square in Vatican City.

Hamas pledged to release the last living American hostage in Gaza, Edan Alexander, in a bid to reestablish a cease-fire with Israel. **A6.**

The Treasury secretary said much progress was made in marathon trade talks with Chinese officials but no details were released. **A4.**

A Worcester rally against the aggressive actions of immigration agents followed a chaotic detainment last week of a mother and the arrest by Worcester police of her child. **B1.**

The Red Sox rode the arm of Lucas Giolito and the bat of Rafael Devers to victory, 3-1, over Kansas City. **C1.**

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Glow-ray days

Monday: Gorgeous, sunny. High 69-74, low 54-59.

Tuesday: More sun, cooler. High 60-65, low 49-54.

Sunrise: 5:26. Sunset: 7:56.

Weather and comics, **D4-5.**

Obituaries, **C9.**

VOL. 307, NO. 132

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Suggested retail price
\$4.00



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